The India Today Group's Best Colleges Survey was first conducted in 1997. In its first year, only engineering, medical and law colleges were ranked. The following year, Arts, Science and Commerce were added. Over the years, as the methodology was constantly updated to ensure the evaluation remained robust and objective, the rankings saw the addition of new streams such as Architecture, Dental Sciences, Mass Communication, Hotel Management, BBA, BCA, Social Work and Fashion Design. In its 26th year, a look back at the No. 1 institutes across all streams. The competition has been tough, but several toppers have retained their dominance.

